

participate in activities for their college applications and who couldn't. My artsy friends in different grades, many of whom were immigrants or lower middle class, had after-school jobs. Many of them came from single-parent households and were required to take on extra obligations, like driving their siblings home and watching them, that prevented them from reaching the top of the crop. It's hard to play on two sports teams and edit the yearbook when you've got three little brothers to look after.

I remember one girl at my school, an immigrant from Europe whom I had a crush on. She was a year above me, and when it came time for everyone to decide where they were going to college, she was one of the only people in her grade who simply wasn't going. I was shocked at the idea that anyone just *wouldn't* go to college. It was 2004. Every TV show on the WB had a college acceptance episode. Every movie was about finally graduating and going off to college. College was sports and romance and freedom and the future. I was confused because she was immensely talented and would have been a competitive candidate.

She told me she couldn't go to college because she was undocumented. I hadn't known that. And even if she hadn't been, her family couldn't afford it because her mother worked under the table for cash. They were *personas non grata*. She wasn't sure what she was going to do after graduation. Maybe stay in South Florida, live at home, and get a job. Maybe just move to a city and find a retail or service industry gig to survive.

I was so angry for her. I thought it wasn't fair that someone with direction and who worked hard, like her, wouldn't go to college. The college admissions process, it turns out, wasn't about justice. Education was directly tied to money.



When I was in high school, I worked for a time as a catering waiter at my synagogue. The temple had an in-house catering service for weddings and bar and bat mitzvahs hosted in its ballroom, and a few of the local kids worked there. We had to show up way before the event, in our black and white uniforms, and set up the whole party, which sucked. But we also got free dinners every time,